RESEARCH MEMO · FALL 2024

Enrollment recovered. The latest growth looks different.

A concise research and publication-QA memo on U.S. nonresident enrollment at degree-granting U.S. institutions.

Fall 2024 provisional | 2015-2024 | 50 states + DC

BOTTOM LINE

Recovery is national. Its composition is not the same as before.

U.S. nonresident enrollment reached **1,044,137** in Fall 2024, or **5.31%** of enrollment in the analytic universe. That is **+63,400** students above 2015.

The newest annual movement breaks with the decade-level pattern. From 2023 to 2024, undergraduate U.S. nonresident enrollment increased **+31,592**, while graduate enrollment declined **-2,053**. The result was a net increase of **+29,539**.

Three findings that matter

01 **The recovery became graduate-heavy**

Graduate enrollment is +138,765 above 2015; undergraduate enrollment is -75,365 below it.

02 **State recovery remains uneven**

33 states/DC are at or above 2019; 18 remain below. FL led the latest annual increase at +6,207.

03 **Institution-universe change does not explain the gain**

Continuing institutions contribute +66,981 over 2015-2024, while universe entry/exit nets to -3,581.

AT A GLANCE

Fall 2024
1,044,137

Change since 2015
+6.5%

2023-2024
+2.9%

High-priority QA flags
27

Manually reviewed
27

NCES benchmark checks
24/24

ANALYST JUDGMENT

A flag does not automatically become a finding

The same QA process can lead to three different publication decisions. These examples are drawn from the current evidence-backed review log.

HOLD THE ANOMALY

University of the Cumberlands

+4,616 students

IPEDS reports 4,226 U.S. nonresident students in 2022, zero in 2023, and 4,616 in 2024, with all three values marked reported. The institution's own materials show an active international-student program, but they do not provide a directly comparable 2023 count. Retain the official IPEDS value in aggregates, flag the discontinuity, and do not use the 2023 zero in institution-specific narrative without direct source confirmation.

Hold institution-specific claim

Review evidence

CORROBORATE THE DIRECTION

Trine University-Regional/Non-Traditional Campuses

+1,441 students

IPEDS reports 7,772 to 9,213 U.S. nonresident students and 8,230 to 9,868 total fall enrollment. Trine independently reported that fall 2024 enrollment across its locations and platforms was expected to rise about 18% from fall 2023, with substantial growth in graduate/hybrid programs. This corroborates the direction and scale of growth, though the institution-wide announcement is not an exact IPEDS U.S. nonresident reconciliation.

Publish with context

Review evidence

EXPLAIN THE STRUCTURAL CHANGE

The College of Saint Rose

-115 students

The institution leaves the 2024 analytic universe after reporting 115 U.S. nonresident students in 2023. New York State Education Department records The College of Saint Rose as closed on December 31, 2024, with academic instruction ending earlier in 2024. The universe exit is therefore an expected structural event rather than an unexplained data disappearance.

Publish with context

Review evidence

INTERPRETATION BOUNDARY

What this memo can support

Population

IPEDS U.S. nonresident status is a federal reporting category. It is not a complete measure of immigrant-origin, undocumented, DACA, foreign-born, or all international students. The population crosswalk documents which companion source should answer each of those questions.

Use

The analysis supports enrollment monitoring and publication QA. It does not identify the causes of enrollment change or estimate immigration-policy effects.

Evidence

Official source archives, schema audits, arithmetic reconciliation, external NCES benchmarking, and institution-level evidence review are kept separate so each claim can be traced to its support.

Publication

Unresolved institution anomalies remain in official aggregate calculations but are withheld from institution-specific narrative until directly comparable evidence is available.

Methods and source trail

Primary measure

The series uses NCES/IPEDS Fall Enrollment `EFNRALT` for U.S. nonresident students. The analytic universe is degree-granting institutions in the First Look/Digest Title IV selection, located in the 50 states and District of Columbia.

Population comparability

IPEDS U.S. nonresident, SEVIS international-student records, CPS immigrant-origin estimates, and ACS-derived undocumented-student estimates answer different questions. The project maintains a separate population/source crosswalk before any companion comparison is attempted.

Release control

Historical revised IPEDS files are preferred when available. Fall 2024 is treated as provisional. Source URLs, archive sizes, retrieval records, and SHA-256 hashes are retained so later revisions can be distinguished from analysis errors.

Independent checks

All 24 NCES Digest consistency checks pass. State, institutional-control, and student-level aggregates reconcile to the national series, and institution entry/exit accounting is separated from continuing-institution change.

Publication QA

The latest-release queue contains 27 high-priority records. 27 high-priority records have evidence-backed manual dispositions; unresolved cases remain in official aggregate calculations but are withheld from institution-specific claims.

Use boundary

This is an enrollment-monitoring and research-QA product. It does not estimate causal policy effects and it does not convert one immigration-related population definition into another.

Portfolio research demonstration. Not affiliated with NCES or the Presidents' Alliance on Higher Education and Immigration.